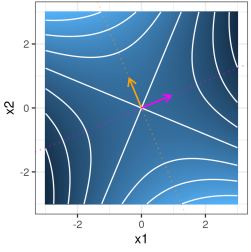
Optimization in Machine Learning

Mathematical Concepts
Quadratic functions II

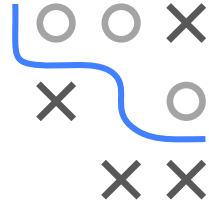


Learning goals

- Geometry of quadratic forms
- Spectrum of Hessian

PROPERTIES OF QUADRATIC FUNCTIONS

Recall: Quadratic form q



- Univariate: $q(x) = ax^2 + bx + c$
- Multivariate: $q(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{x}^T\mathbf{A}\mathbf{x} + \boldsymbol{b}^T\mathbf{x} + c$

General observation: If $q \geq 0$ ($q \leq 0$), q is convex (concave)

Univariate function: Second derivative is $q''(x) = 2a$

- $q''(x) \overset{(>)}{\geq} 0$: q (strictly) convex. $q''(x) \overset{(<)}{\leq} 0$: q (strictly) concave.
- High (low) absolute values of $q''(x)$: high (low) curvature

Multivariate function: Second derivative is $\mathbf{H} = 2\mathbf{A}$

- Convexity/concavity of q depend on eigenvalues of $\mathbf{H}$
- Let us look at an example of the form $q(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{x}^T\mathbf{A}\mathbf{x}$

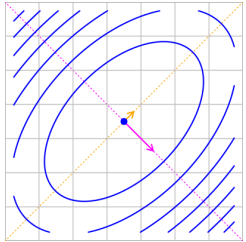
GEOMETRY OF QUADRATIC FUNCTIONS

Example: $\mathbf{A} = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & -1 \\ -1 & 2 \end{pmatrix} \implies \mathbf{H} = 2\mathbf{A} = \begin{pmatrix} 4 & -2 \\ -2 & 4 \end{pmatrix}$

- Since $\mathbf{H}$ symmetric, eigendecomposition $\mathbf{H} = \mathbf{V}\Lambda\mathbf{V}^T$ with

$$\mathbf{V} = \begin{pmatrix} | & | \\ v_{\max} & v_{\min} \\ | & | \end{pmatrix} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ -1 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \text{ orthogonal}$$

$$\text{and } \Lambda = \begin{pmatrix} \lambda_{\max} & 0 \\ 0 & \lambda_{\min} \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} 6 & 0 \\ 0 & 2 \end{pmatrix}.$$

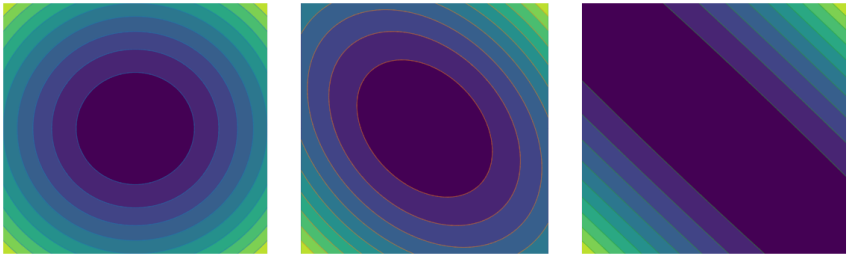


CONDITION AND CURVATURE

Condition of $\mathbf{H} = 2\mathbf{A}$ is given by $\kappa(\mathbf{H}) = \kappa(\mathbf{A}) = |\lambda_{\text{max}}|/|\lambda_{\text{min}}|$.

High condition means:

- $|\lambda_{\text{max}}| \gg |\lambda_{\text{min}}|$
- Curvature along $\boldsymbol{v}_{\text{max}} \gg$ curvature along $\boldsymbol{v}_{\text{min}}$
- **Problem** for optimization algorithms like **gradient descent** (later)

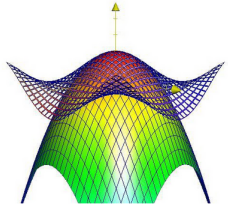


Left: Excellent condition. **Middle:** Good condition. **Right:** Bad condition.

APPROXIMATION OF SMOOTH FUNCTIONS

Any function $f \in \mathcal{C}^2$ can be locally approximated by a quadratic function via second order Taylor approximation:

$$f(\mathbf{x}) \approx f(\tilde{\boldsymbol{x}}) + \nabla f(\tilde{\boldsymbol{x}})(\mathbf{x} - \tilde{\boldsymbol{x}}) + \frac{1}{2}(\mathbf{x} - \tilde{\boldsymbol{x}})^T \nabla^2 f(\tilde{\boldsymbol{x}})(\mathbf{x} - \tilde{\boldsymbol{x}})$$



f and its second order approximation is shown by the dark and bright grid, respectively. (Source: `daniloroccatano.blog`)

$\Longrightarrow$ Hessians provide information about **local** geometry of a function.